

BIHAR ORIGIN

Kadhi Bari

Yogurt Curry with Sun-Dried Lentil Nuggets
Bihar's Distinctive Take on a Pan-Indian Classic

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Kadhi Bar

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Kadhi Bari

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Preserved Sunshine in Every Bite

While kadhi — a tangy yogurt and gram flour curry — appears in some form across much of North and Central India, Bihar's version distinguishes itself through what goes into the pot alongside the yogurt: bari, small sun-dried lentil dumplings made and preserved specifically for use throughout the year, rather than the freshly fried pakora fritters found in Punjabi-style kadhi.

Making bari is itself a seasonal ritual in many Bihari households — a paste of urad dal (or a mix of lentils) is shaped into small nuggets and dried in the sun over several days, traditionally during the hotter, drier months when the process works most reliably, then stored for months and used gradually as needed. This practice of preserving lentil protein in dried form reflects a broader pattern in Bihari and eastern Indian cooking of preparing ingredients well ahead of when they're needed, adapting to seasonal availability and storage limitations that shaped rural kitchens for generations.

When rehydrated and simmered in the tangy yogurt gravy, bari take on a distinctive chewy-tender texture quite different from fried pakora, giving Bihar's kadhi bari its own genuinely distinct character within India's many regional kadhi traditions.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Preserved Sunshine in Every Bite, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Bihar's distinctive regional variation of the pan-Indian kadhi tradition, defined by dried lentil dumplings (bari) rather than fried pakora fritters. Bari-making is a seasonal household ritual in many Bihari families, with dumplings sun-dried in batches and stored for year-round use. Reflects a broader Bihari and eastern Indian tradition of preserving ingredients in advance to adapt to seasonal availability. A dish that showcases genuine regional distinctiveness within a curry style found, in various forms, across much of India.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	40m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Large, heavy-bottomed pot
- Whisk, for the yogurt-besan mixture
- Small pan for the tempering

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Kadhi bari keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days, with the bari continuing to soften and absorb the gravy's flavor over time. It doesn't freeze particularly well, as the yogurt-based gravy's texture suffers on thawing. Dried, unsoaked bari themselves keep for months in an airtight container in a cool, dry place — the traditional point of making them in the first place.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the bari (or store-bought)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Store-bought dried bari (urad dal nuggets)	1 cup	100 g	1 katori

For the kadhi

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Plain yogurt, well-fermented	2 cups	480 g	2 katori
Besan (gram flour)	⅓ cup	40 g	⅓ katori
Water	4 cups	1 L	4 katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

For the tempering (tadka)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Fenugreek seeds	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Dried red chilies	2	2	2
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the tempering (tadka) (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Curry leaves — optional	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Dried bari can be found at Indian grocers, often labeled "urad dal bari" or "mangodi" (a related North Indian dried lentil dumpling that works as a close substitute). If bari genuinely isn't available, fried gram flour pakora fritters can substitute, though the dish will taste closer to Punjabi-style kadhi pakora than the traditional Bihari version. Well-fermented, slightly sour yogurt gives the best flavor — very fresh yogurt can be left at room temperature for a few hours to develop more tang.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Bari and Base

01 SOAK THE BARI

If using dried bari, soak them in warm water for 20–30 minutes until softened slightly, then drain. This step isn't needed if using fresh pakora as a substitute.

02 LIGHTLY FRY THE BARI

Heat a little oil in a pan and lightly fry the soaked bari for 2–3 minutes, until they turn slightly golden — this step firms them up before they go into the simmering kadhi.



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Preparing the Bari and Base, continued

Chef tip. don't over-fry the bari at this stage — they'll continue to soften and cook further once added to the simmering kadhi.

03 WHISK THE YOGURT BASE

In a large bowl, whisk together the yogurt and besan until completely smooth, then gradually whisk in the water, turmeric, and salt.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The yogurt-besan mixture should be completely smooth with no lumps before it goes into the pot — any lumps at this stage will remain in the finished kadhi.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Simmering the Kadhi

04 BRING TO A SIMMER

Pour the yogurt mixture into a large pot and bring to a gentle boil, stirring frequently to prevent the besan from settling and scorching at the bottom.

05 ADD THE BARI AND SIMMER

Reduce heat and add the lightly fried bari. Simmer for 25–30 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the kadhi thickens and the raw besan taste is completely gone.



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Simmering the Kadhi, continued

Texture indicator. the bari should turn soft and slightly chewy, having absorbed some of the tangy gravy, while the kadhi itself coats the back of a spoon smoothly.

06 FINISH WITH TEMPERING

Heat mustard oil in a small pan, add cumin and fenugreek seeds, letting them sizzle, then the dried red chilies, asafoetida, red chili powder, and curry leaves if using. Pour the sizzling tempering over the kadhi just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling the kadhi too vigorously, especially in the first 10 minutes, can cause the yogurt to split. Keep it at a gentle simmer throughout, stirring regularly rather than letting it sit unattended.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot over steamed rice, a comforting everyday meal especially popular in the colder months.
- A practical dish for using pantry-stored bari, made without needing fresh vegetables.

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How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A large shared pot ladled generously over rice for the whole family.

Modern Pairing

- Works well alongside simple roti for those who prefer bread over rice.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- Well-fermented, sour yogurt is essential for proper tang — very fresh yogurt makes a noticeably milder kadhi.
- Lightly frying the bari before adding them to the kadhi firms up their texture and helps them hold together during the long simmer.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Dried bari, once made or purchased, keep for months, making this a genuinely convenient pantry-based dish for busy periods.
- The kadhi itself is best made fresh, though leftovers reheat reasonably well over gentle heat.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some households add a pinch of sugar to balance an especially sour batch of yogurt — a small, commonly used adjustment across many kadhi traditions.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

210 kcal	9 g	18 g	12 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Bihari Kadhi Bari	the traditional version featured here, using sun-dried lentil nuggets.
Kadhi with Fresh Pakora	a shortcut version using freshly fried gram flour fritters instead of dried bari.
Plain Kadhi	a simpler version without any dumplings, just the tangy yogurt gravy on its own.

Can I make my own bari at home?

Yes — traditionally made by shaping a thick urad dal paste into small nuggets and sun-drying over several days, though this requires consistent hot, dry weather and several days of patience.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Where can I buy dried bari?

Indian grocers often stock them, sometimes labeled "bari," "badi," or the related "mangodi" — check the dried goods or lentil section.

Why did my kadhi split?

Usually boiling too vigorously, especially early in cooking, or using very fresh (non-sour) yogurt. Keep heat gentle and use properly fermented yogurt.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Bari	sun-dried lentil dumplings, the defining ingredient of Bihari-style kadhi.
Besan	gram flour, the thickening base for the kadhi itself.
Mangodi	a related North Indian dried lentil dumpling, a close substitute for bari.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot oil, poured over the dish to finish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Kadhi Bari

10m	40m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

BARI (OR STORE-BOUGHT)

Store-bought dried bari	100 g

KADHI

Plain yogurt	480 g
Besan	40 g
Water	1 L
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	6 g

TEMPERING (TADKA)

Mustard oil	45 ml
Cumin seeds	4 g
Fenugreek seeds	1 g
Dried red chilies	2
Asafoetida	pinch
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Curry leaves — optional	8–10 leaves

METHOD

01 **Soak the bari.** If using dried bari, soak them in warm water for 20–30 minutes until softened slightly, then drain.

02 **Lightly fry the bari.** Heat a little oil in a pan and lightly fry the soaked bari for 2–3 minutes, until they turn slightly golden — this step firms them up before they go into the simmering kadhi.

03 **Whisk the yogurt base.** In a large bowl, whisk together the yogurt and besan until completely smooth, then gradually whisk in the water, turmeric, and salt.

04 **Bring to a simmer.** Pour the yogurt mixture into a large pot and bring to a gentle boil, stirring frequently to prevent the besan from settling and scorching at the bottom.

05 **Add the bari and simmer.** Reduce heat and add the lightly fried bari.

06 **Finish with tempering.** Heat mustard oil in a small pan, add cumin and fenugreek seeds, letting them sizzle, then the dried red chilies, asafoetida, red chili powder, and curry leaves if using.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Store-bought dried bari	100 g	☐ Plain yogurt	480 g
☐ Besan	40 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Mustard oil	45 ml
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Fenugreek seeds	1 g
☐ Dried red chilies	2	☐ Asafoetida	pinch
☐ Red chili powder	1.5 g	☐ Curry leaves — optional	8–10 leaves

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